The Wilmot Proviso

Rep. David Wilmot · August 8, 1846

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> Attached to a war-funding bill, this short proviso would have banned slavery from any land won from Mexico. Though it never became law, it inflamed the sectional crisis and helped give rise to the antislavery Republican Party.

The full text of the proviso

Provided, That, as an express and fundamental condition to the acquisition of any territory from the Republic of Mexico by the United States, by virtue of any treaty which may be negotiated between them, and to the use by the Executive of the moneys herein appropriated, neither slavery nor involuntary servitude shall ever exist in any part of said territory, except for crime, whereof the party shall first be duly convicted.

Words to know

Provided — on the condition that; legal word introducing a requirement

appropriated — set aside by Congress for a specific spending purpose

involuntary servitude — forced labor of any kind, not only slavery

duly convicted — properly found guilty in court